

The US Civil War

In 1861, a bitter and bloody war broke out in the US between the northern (or Union) and southern (or Confederate) states. The main cause was slavery. The economy of the South relied on enslaving Black people to work on plantations, while in the industrialized North, public opinion was in favor of ending slavery. The war ended in 1865 with a Union victory.

At the start of the 1860s, almost 4 million out of the US population of 31 million were enslaved Black people. They were forced to do back-breaking work for no wages.

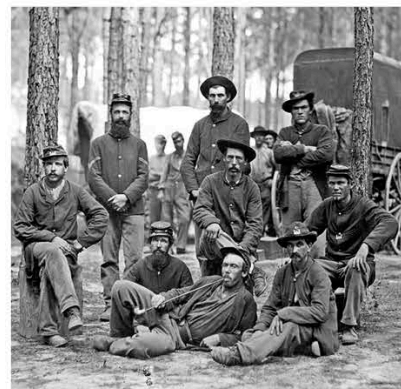
In 1860, Abraham Lincoln won the presidential election on the promise of refusing to extend slavery into the new US territories in the west. Fearing for their future, seven southern states—later joined by four more—left the Union to form the Confederate States of America. When Lincoln refused to hand over military property to the new government, Confederate forces attacked.

Both sides raised large armies, the Confederates winning the early battles due to their superior military leadership. But in 1863, Union forces took control of the Mississippi River

and split the states of Texas and Arkansas from the rest of the Confederacy. Their victory soon after at Gettysburg was decisive. Union forces attacked the Confederacy from all directions, wrecking its economy, and finally defeating it in 1865.

EVERYDAY LIFE

The US Civil War was the first conflict to be photographed in detail, and was well recorded by journalists in newspapers and magazines. Seen here is a group of Union soldiers in camp.



CONFEDERATE BREAKAWAY ►

The US Civil War began in April 1861 when Confederate forces bombarded the Union-held Fort Sumter (right) in South Carolina. Four southern states that had remained in the Union until then joined the Confederacy after this attack.



MAJOR EVENTS

1861

The first major land battle of the war is fought at Bull Run in Virginia, resulting in a huge Confederate victory.

1862

The first-ever battle between ironclad warships—the Union's USS *Monitor* and the Confederate's CSS *Virginia*—takes place at Hampton Roads in Virginia.



1862

Union forces win a narrow victory at Shiloh near Pittsburgh Landing in Tennessee, weakening the Confederacy.